Session 15

2025-06-29

1 - Before the road

~13:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Before the wheels turn, Amidamaru begs a loan around the party for spell-scribing supplies: three platinum from Eguzkilore, a scatter of coin from Nyx, ten gold from Mialee — enough for a scroll's worth of paper and ink at twenty-five gold the sheet.
2. He goes hunting the supplies through Baldur's Gate on his own and hits a wall — no shop within reach carries the mage-grade paper he needs. After a while he cuts his losses and returns to the group without the goods.
3. Nuberroca sets out for a small healing potion — the only strength his budget stretches to at fifty gold, when a medium bottle would run him two hundred. Amidamaru quietly buys one on his behalf and lodges the tab — when the trip is done, he will collect the coin.
4. The party takes a beat to think about disguise — this is an infiltration, the sensible ones should change something about how they look. Nyx picks up a spare cloak and a hood off the merchant's supply; Mialee takes a small cape. Amidamaru already keeps his elf-face illusion. Nuberroca goes the other way — chest out, the Order of the Gauntlet emblem on plain view, watching every face for the flinch of recognition he saw at the north gate.
5. Amidamaru shares that half an hour ago Munin, his owl familiar, caught a hooded figure and eight riders leaving the cultist inn on horseback, taking the north road at speed. He sends Munin up to trail them, watching through the owl's eyes as far as the bond carries; once the owl outruns his reach no new order will follow. The last command he leaves is *watch*. By roll-out the owl is back with him.

2 - Caravan assembly

1. Ten carts assemble in the yard by the Black Dragon Gate. Five carry the merchants — the three who hired the party plus the ale-seller who did not; two are traveller carts riding along; the last three sit at the front of the line, the group the party suspects for cultists.
2. **Lai Angesstun**'s cart is first up front, the gold-dwarf and his caravan-veteran guard **Eldkin** paired to it; behind them ride Nyx as his sergeant and Eguzkilore under her, with Eldkin's own remark that the road-experience should have made her the sergeant instead.
3. **Edhelri Lewel**'s two wagons of wood take Mialee at the bodyguard's spot and Nuberroca as her sergeant.
4. **Noohar Serelim** and his brother **Selvek** ride the third wagon with Amidamaru minding both of them.
5. The last of the four is **Beyd** the half-elf, his cart stacked entire with barrels of ale for the road; he travels with one guard, **Sulesdeg**, close to seven and a half feet tall — shorter than the goliath but taller than any other man on the road.
6. Nuberroca and Amidamaru, nearest the cultist wagons in the yard, take the closest look; neither can match a face from the cave to any of the guards or drivers.
7. The party gets shown the road on a Sword Coast map — Baldur's Gate up the Trade Way through the Trollclaws to Waterdeep, the direct line rather than the longer detour. Fifteen miles a day, six days of travel and one of rest — two months in all.
   Nuberroca sees the catch plain enough — there is a stretch full of troll caverns and the merchants think the sensible thing is to walk the road straight through the middle of it. The merchants have counted their coin: the detour would add nearly a month, and guards are cheaper than lost weeks.

3 – On the road

~14:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The ten carts roll out of Baldur's Gate a couple of hours past midday, well later than the merchants had wanted. The formation settles by itself — the three cultist wagons at the head with their own drivers and guards, the three party-merchant carts in the middle, the ale wagon and the two traveller carts trailing. The sun is up strong for the season; it is autumn but the afternoon is hot, and the land opens out into flat country with sparse woodland — good sightlines and almost no shade.
2. Nuberroca makes for the traveller cart — a family, three children and their parents, moving north because Baldur's Gate has soured for them — a bad run of luck in the city, corruption thick enough to drive them out, and Waterdeep is where they mean to start again. He stands full-height alongside the seated father, puts his chest on show and rolls the pecs one at a time, pushing a muscle-tensing sound through his teeth — his name is Nuberroca, and if they need help on the road he is here to serve them. The family's two mounted guards ride up beside the cart without drawing steel; the father thanks him and, in the same breath, hopes not to need him on the road.
3. The family's story does not quite settle Nuberroca — a run of bad luck reads to him like a cover, and he wants to know what a supposedly-civilian family is really hauling. He fakes a stumble into the cartside and listens: for the ring of metal in the wood, for anything shifting inside. Nothing metallic, only voices asking whether he is alright. Mialee walks over and pulls him back to their own line.
4. Nyx puts the question in a lull of the ride — has anyone here fought trolls before? — and gets nothing useful; her own knowledge is rumour only, that they are big and ugly. Amidamaru suggests Mialee try her charm on the other bodyguards, on the reasoning that they will have seen more of the road than the party has.
5. Nyx murmurs a small blessing over her own eyes as she pushes forward through the caravan, then studies each of the three cultist wagons in turn from a middling distance — she is looking for a face she remembers from the cave. Nothing lands; the wagons are all tarpaulined tight, and Lai's own oil-and-perfume cart looks no different from the outside. She moves on to the head of the caravan and keeps her watch there.
6. Mialee walks over to Beyd's cart to work him for information alongside a deal on the beer. A full barrel — the man carries barrels, not small kegs — runs fifty jars of ale; Beyd would sell her one for forty-seven silver, three under market. Mialee closes the deal, then keeps him talking: he runs this road often, there is always a bandit or a monster somewhere, but a torch usually settles the trolls quickly enough. Then she puts the question about his guard, so tall — the man's real name is **Sulesdeg**, but everyone on the road calls him *The Pole* because he stands tall as a lodge pole.
7. Sometime in the ride the wages come clear from the merchants — sixty gold for a bodyguard at journey's end, forty-eight for a sergeant, thirty for a guard: six tendays' rate on a two-month trip, and only if the job is done clean.
8. Riding on Noohar's cart, Amidamaru asks the brothers whether either of them knows a merchant on the road who might carry magic-grade paper and ink. Selvek meets the question with hand gestures Amidamaru cannot follow. Noohar answers plain for his brother, catching himself mid-sentence — his brother is mute, he cannot speak — then reaches for the answer proper: the caravan people he knows carry stranger cargo than paper, and he cannot help. He does know Beyd from other trips, and knows Eldkin too — has seen her fight bandits, and once a troll.
9. Amidamaru calls Munin down onto his shoulder for the brothers to see and pledges the owl to them as a second pair of eyes on the road — in a fight the bird will come to them and watch over them as he would. To Selvek and Noohar he lays it out — with the owl beside him, he stands as two.
10. Amidamaru walks a slow *detect magic* through the caravan as a ritual, standing off close to each cart in turn — no arcane user among the guards or the merchants. He drops the plan out loud: at each halt he will walk the caravan again, twice a day if the stops hold long enough.

4 – First halt

~17:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. After three hours on the road the carts start braking to a stop for the first short rest. The three groups pull apart at the halt the way they had on the road — the three cultist merchants form up alone to the front, Lai, Edhelri and Noohar together in the middle, and Beyd walks a barrel over to the family and the second traveller cart to work the fire for a sale.
2. The meals divide by employer. Lai serves rice and beans to Kaelthar, Nyx and Eguzkilore — the same food he takes himself, and Eldkin knows him well enough for a skinflint to sneak dried meat from her own bag into the pot for a bit of flavour. Edhelri feeds Mialee and Nuberroca better — puffed wheat, cured meat, some vegetables, meal worth serving to a guest. Around the fires the party watches for anything out of order and comes up empty.
3. Beyd rolls his barrel through the party's fire before the halt breaks up — ten copper the jar, though the same beer runs two coppers back in the city. Nuberroca turns him down flat — beer dulls the senses; maybe when the watch is done — and gets up to walk it off — a refusal that surprises Mialee at the fire. Amidamaru takes a jar, on a two-copper deposit for the mug, and hands it to one of the brothers when he comes back to the cart.

5 – Night camp

~18:30, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan pushes another two hours after the halt, aiming to close out the day early — eight in the evening by the time the light goes soft and the guards start lighting the wagon lamps. Amidamaru keeps Munin low overhead through the dusk — high in daylight, low in the dark. Two riders cross the road going the other way at a trot; brief nods around; Amidamaru shouts after them asking for paper and ink, and they ride on giving him strange looks.
2. The wheels stop for the night off the road. This stretch of the Trade Way has no villages or inns; tonight, they sleep in the open. Carts settle into the three groups they had held all day; harness comes off, and Eldkin walks the horses down for the day's sweat, rubbing them clean. Nyx and Nuberroca are told to keep eyes on the animals; Nyx passes the job on to Eguzkilore and Eldkin and slips into the trees to hunt a rabbit for Eldkin's fire, angling for a little goodwill. No game to be had in the dark.
3. Eguzkilore, needing only half a night's trance, offers to take the last four hours of the watch straight through — a shift worth a lot of gratitude from the rest of the guards.

6 – Spear and pebble

~21:00, 6 Uktar 1489 DR

1. With the camp settled and the guards patrolling, Nuberroca crosses to the cultist carts spear in hand — pauses ten feet off the first, brings the point up to the tarp; a guard rises off the ground and shouts him back — away from the merchandise. He moves on to the second cart and repeats the pass; the guard tracks him with his eyes and does not intervene, but the message is clear enough.
2. Amidamaru, watching Nuberroca work cart to cart, drops ten copper into a passing guard's hand with a pebble in the other — carry this to the goliath. The guard takes the coin and the errand. The pebble reads unremarkable in the palm; touched to the ear, a whispered voice comes out of it — an artificer's small craft. To Nuberroca the whisper carries Amidamaru's warning: the front of the caravan already knows him, stop drawing attention.
3. Nuberroca hears it and walks back to his post — then shouts *Look out! Defend yourselves!* across the camp to test the caravan. Every guard down the line comes up with blades or crossbows out; the front carts move exactly the same as the rest. Nuberroca declares it a false alarm — a flash of light in the sky — and waves off the half that keeps staring with a small regal flick of the wrist, all swagger and grin.
4. Over dinner Amidamaru works his way around the rest of the party in turn — a hand on a shoulder, a pebble pressed to a pocket, an ear leaned in for the whisper: they are all being watched, everyone should keep their distance from Nuberroca specifically. Nuberroca's own pendant — a glow Amidamaru had strung on it — quietly goes dark on his chest.

7 – The night watch

1. Amidamaru drops a spell of *invisibility* on Munin and sends the owl out to skim the cultist carts at eavesdropping range — whatever the owl's fine hearing catches, Amidamaru will catch too. Half an hour of listening turns up nothing worth carrying back.
2. Nyx sets a silent *alarm* over the far end of the middle cultist cart — a twenty-foot square, mental rather than audible, meant to catch anyone stepping in or out of it in the night. She lays it from over thirty feet off, so the cultists cannot see the working, and folds her whispered casting into what looks like a conversation with a nearby ally.
3. She wakes about an hour or two into her sleep to the alarm — mental, silent to the camp. When she lifts her head to look, it is only one of the caravan's own guards leaning on the cart mid-patrol. She lies back down.
4. The rest of the night passes without further incident — a first uneventful night of what is to be a two-month road.